1. Basic facts

Full name and other names

- **Full name: Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (born April 14, 1891, Mhow, India—died December 6, 1956, New Delhi)"
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- **Birth surname: Sakpal (registered at school as Ambadawekar)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His original surname was Sakpal but his father registered his name as Ambadawekar in school, meaning he comes from his native village 'Ambadawe'"
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- **School surname change to Ambedkar** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His Marathi Brahmin teacher, Krishnaji Keshav Ambedkar, changed his surname from 'Ambadawekar' to his own surname 'Ambedkar' in school records."
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- **Other name: Babasaheb** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (14 April 1891 – 6 December 1956), popularly known as Babasaheb Ambedkar"
-

Born and died

- **Born: 14 April 1891 in Mhow, Central Provinces (now Madhya Pradesh), India** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (born April 14, 1891, Mhow, India—died December 6, 1956, New Delhi)"
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- **Died: 6 December 1956 in New Delhi, India, in his sleep from illness (including diabetes)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Since 1948, Ambedkar edited his diary and suffered from diabetes. He remained in bed from June to October in 1954 due to medication side-effects and poor eyesight... He died in his sleep on 6 December 1956 at his home in Delhi."
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Family, education, work

- **Parents: 14th and youngest child of Ramji Maloji Sakpal (an army Subedar) and Bhimabai Sakpal** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "He was the 14th and last child of Ramji Maloji Sakpal, an army officer who held the rank of Subedar, and Bhimabai Sakpal"
-
- **First marriage (Version A — 1906): Married nine-year-old Ramabai in 1906 when he was 15** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1906, when he was about 15 years old, he married a nine-year-old girl, Ramabai."
-
- **First marriage (Version B — 1907): Married Ramabai in 1907** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Ambedkar with his wife Ramabai in 1907"
-

- **Second marriage: Married Dr. Sharada Kabir (Savita Ambedkar) on 15 April 1948** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "He wed Savita Ambedkar (born Sharada Kabir), a Brahmin doctor, on 15 April 1948"
-
- **B.A. at Elphinstone College (1912) and Baroda scholarship to Columbia University (1913)** | LSE History Blog | "He graduated from Elphinstone College, University of Bombay in 1912. In 1913 he was awarded a Baroda State Scholarship and moved to Columbia University, New York"
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- **M.A. (1915) and Ph.D. (earned 1917, awarded 1927) at Columbia University** | Columbia University Libraries | "In 1915, he submitted an M. A. thesis entitled: The Administration and Finance of the East India Company."
-
- **Called to the Bar at Gray's Inn and awarded D.Sc. from the London School of Economics (1923)** | South Asian Britain | "In 1923 he was called to the Bar and received his DSc. He then returned to India and set up a legal practice in Bombay."
-
- **Worked as Probationer in the Accountant General's Office in Baroda State (1917)** | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "The Maharaja of Baroda was Boys' Scholar, and so I was bound to serve the Baroda State. I returned to India and joined the Baroda State Service as a probationer in the Accountant General's Office."
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- **Professor of Political Economy at Sydenham College, Bombay (1918–1920)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1918, he became professor of political economy in the Sydenham College of Commerce and Economics in Mumbai."
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- **Chairman of the Drafting Committee of the Constituent Assembly and First Law Minister of India (1947–1951)** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "He served as the first law minister of the government of India (1947–51)."
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Groups and organisations they belonged to

- **Columbia University and London School of Economics (student and alumnus)** | LSE History Blog | "Dr B R Ambedkar first visited LSE in 1916, returned in 1921 and submitted his doctoral thesis in 1923."
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- **Honorable Society of Gray's Inn, London** | LSE History Blog | "At the same time Ambedkar enrolled for the bar course at Gray's Inn."
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- **Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha (founded 1924)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His first organised attempt was his establishment of the central institution Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha, intended to promote education and socio-economic improvement"
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- **Independent Labour Party (founded 1936)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1936, Ambedkar founded the Independent Labour Party, which contested the 1937 Bombay election to the Central Legislative Assembly"
-
- **Scheduled Castes Federation (founded 1942)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Ambedkar oversaw the transformation of his political party into the Scheduled Castes Federation."
-
- **Viceroy's Executive Council (Labour Member, 1942–1946)** | South Asian Britain | "Ambedkar also served on the Defense Advisory Committee and the Viceroy's Executive Council as Minister for Labor."
-
- **Constituent Assembly of India (Drafting Committee Chairman, 1947–1949)** | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "On 29 August, he was appointed Chairman of the Constitution Drafting Committee, and was appointed by the Assembly to write India's new Constitution."
-

The 5 to 10 most important events in their life (in date order)

1. **1907 — Passed the matriculation exam and received a biography of the Buddha:** Became one of the first untouchable students in Bombay Presidency to pass high school matriculation, and received a book on the Buddha at a community celebration. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "This success provoked celebrations in his community, and it was at this occasion that he was presented with a biography of the Buddha by Dada Keluskar"
2.
3. **July 1913 – June 1916 — Studied at Columbia University in New York:** Earned his M.A. and completed his doctoral coursework under professors including John Dewey and Edwin Seligman. | Columbia University Libraries | "In 1915, he submitted an M. A. thesis entitled: The Administration and Finance of the East India Company."
4.
5. **1917 — Forced out of Baroda after 11 days because no one would rent a room to an untouchable:** Returned to work for Baroda State, hid under a Parsi name at an inn, and was chased out by men with sticks when his caste was discovered. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "I decided to spend the five hours in the public garden which is called Kamathi Baug... and return to Bombay, after a stay of only eleven days."
6.
7. **January 1920 — Started the Marathi newspaper *Mooknayak* ("Leader of the Voiceless"):** Launched his first newspaper in Bombay with financial support from the Maharaja of Kolhapur. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1920, he began the publication of the weekly Mooknayak (Leader of the Silent) in Mumbai with the help of Shahu of Kolhapur"
8.

9. **1923 — Completed his D.Sc. at LSE and was called to the Bar at Gray's Inn:** Finished his doctoral thesis *The Problem of the Rupee* in London and qualified as a barrister. | LSE History Blog | "The thesis was resubmitted in August 1923 and accepted in November 1923."
10.
11. **March & December 1927 — Led the Mahad Satyagraha for water rights:** Led thousands of Dalits to drink water from the public Chavdar Tank in Mahad, and publicly burned copies of the *Manusmriti* in December 1927. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "He led a satyagraha in Mahad to fight for the right of the untouchable community to draw water from the main water tank of the town."
12.
13. **March 1930 — Launched the Kalaram Temple Satyagraha in Nashik:** Organised around 15,000 volunteers in a nonviolent march demanding temple entry for untouchables. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1930, Ambedkar launched the Kalaram Temple movement... About 15,000 volunteers assembled at Kalaram Temple satygraha"
14.
15. **1930–1932 — Represented the Depressed Classes at the Round Table Conferences in London:** Argued before the British government for political rights and separate electorates for untouchables. | South Asian Britain | "In 1930 he was invited to attend the Round Table Conference in London."
16.
17. **24 September 1932 — Signed the Poona Pact at Yerwada Central Jail:** Negotiated with a fasting Mahatma Gandhi in Pune, giving up separate electorates in exchange for 148 reserved legislative seats for the Depressed Classes. | Constitution of India Archive | "It reserved 148 seats from the general electorate for 'Depressed Classes',78 more than what the Award had proposed."
18.
19. **August 1947 – November 1949 — Chaired the Constitution Drafting Committee and served as First Law Minister:** Appointed Independent India's first Minister of Law on 15 August 1947 and Chairman of the Drafting Committee on 29 August 1947, guiding the Indian Constitution to adoption on 26 November 1949. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "On 29 August, he was appointed Chairman of the Constitution Drafting Committee, and was appointed by the Assembly to write India's new Constitution."
20.

2. Story angles (at least 10)

Angle 1: The Midnight Cart Ride to Goregaon (PERSONAL MEMORY by B. R. Ambedkar)

- **One-line hook:** Nine-year-old Bhim and his brothers dressed in their finest clothes for a train trip to see their father, until a single word left them stranded without water and driving their own bullock cart in the dark.
-
- **Key facts:**

-
    - In 1901, nine-year-old Bhim and his older brother and nephew took the train to Masur to meet his father in Goregaon, cooking their own *pulav* while their father was away. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "We four children went to school, and we also cooked our food. We could not prepare bread. So we lived on Pulav"
    -
    - The Masur stationmaster was friendly because the well-dressed boys looked like Brahmin children, until Bhim told him their caste. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "Without a moment's thought I blurted out that we were Mahars... His face underwent a sudden change."
    -
    - Every cart driver refused to touch them until the stationmaster arranged a deal: the boys had to pay double fare and steer the bullock cart themselves while the driver walked beside it. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "we were to pay the cartman double the fare and drive the cart, and that he should walk on foot along with the cart"
    -
    - Halfway there, the cartman ate his dinner by a pool of smelly muddy water, leaving the boys to sleep hungry in the cart until next morning because they were not allowed to get clean water. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "There was hunger burning within us; with all this we were to sleep without food; that was because we could get no water"
    -

Angle 2: The Gunny Sack and the Locked Water Tap (PERSONAL MEMORY by B. R. Ambedkar)

- **One-line hook:** At Satara High School, young Bhim had to carry his own rough sack to sit on every day—and if the school attendant was absent, he could not drink a single drop of water all day.
-
- **Key facts:**
-

    - At school, Bhim was not allowed to sit on classroom benches with other boys and had to bring his own piece of gunny cloth from home, which even the school cleaner refused to touch. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "I was to have a separate piece of gunny cloth for me to squat on in the classroom, and the servant employed to clean the school would not touch the gunny cloth"
    -
    - He was forbidden to touch the school water tap; only the school peon could turn it on for him to drink. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "I could not touch

the tap... The situation can be summed up in the statement—no peon, no water."

- Because no town barber would cut the hair of an untouchable boy, Bhim's older sister had to shave and cut the brothers' hair at home. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "The work of shaving and hair-cutting was done by my sister because we were untouchables, and no barber would consent to shave an untouchable."

Angle 3: The Teacher Who Shared His Own Surname

- **One-line hook:** Why wasn't Bhimrao called "Sakpal"? Because a kind schoolteacher changed the boy's last name in the school register to match his own.
- **Key facts:**
  - Bhimrao's family surname was Sakpal, and his father first wrote him into the school register as "Ambadawekar" after their home village of Ambadawe. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His original surname was Sakpal but his father registered his name as Ambadawekar in school, meaning he comes from his native village 'Ambadawe'"
  - A Marathi Brahmin teacher named Krishnaji Keshav Ambedkar changed the boy's surname in the school records to "Ambedkar." | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His Marathi Brahmin teacher, Krishnaji Keshav Ambedkar, changed his surname from 'Ambadawekar' to his own surname 'Ambedkar' in school records."

Angle 4: The Book Present That Stayed With Him for 49 Years

- **One-line hook:** When 16-year-old Bhimrao passed his high school exam in 1907, a family friend handed him a small book about the Buddha that changed the rest of his life.
- **Key facts:**
  - In 1907, Bhimrao passed his matriculation exam and entered Elphinstone College at the University of Bombay, prompting a public celebration in his community. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1907, he passed his matriculation examination and in the following year he entered Elphinstone College"
  - At the ceremony, author and social reformer Dada Keluskar gave him a biography of Gautama Buddha that Keluskar had written. | Wikipedia – B. R.

Ambedkar | "it was at this occasion that he was presented with a biography of the Buddha by Dada Keluskar, the author and a family friend."

- Nearly half a century later, in October 1956, Ambedkar formally converted to Buddhism in Nagpur along with hundreds of thousands of followers. | Encyclopædia Britannica | "In October 1956... he renounced Hinduism and became a Buddhist, together with about 200,000 fellow Dalits, at a ceremony in Nagpur."

Angle 5: The Secret Fake Name at the Parsi Inn (PERSONAL MEMORY by B. R. Ambedkar)

- **One-line hook:** Fresh from Columbia University in New York, the new government officer in Baroda had to sign a fake name at an empty inn—until 12 men armed with sticks cornered him in his room.
- **Key facts:**
  - Returning to India to serve the Maharaja of Baroda in 1917, Ambedkar found that no Hindu or Muslim hotel in Baroda would rent him a room, so he asked the caretaker of a Parsi inn to let him stay. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "He agreed, on condition that I pay him a rupee and a half per day for board and lodging, and enter myself as a Parsi in his register."
  - He stayed alone in a dark upstairs room surrounded by bats, until on his eleventh morning he heard heavy footsteps climbing the stairs while he was getting dressed for work. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "Instantly I saw a dozen angry-looking, tall, sturdy Parsis, each armed with a stick, coming towards my room."
  - Ordered to leave by evening and refused temporary housing by both Hindu and Christian friends, he sat weeping under a tree in Kamathi Baug public park for five hours until the 9:00 PM train back to Bombay. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "I decided to spend the five hours in the public garden which is called Kamathi Baug... and return to Bombay, after a stay of only eleven days."

Angle 6: The Thesis Lost to a Torpedoed Ship in World War I

- **One-line hook:** Imagine writing a whole book-length university thesis, only for a German submarine to sink the steamer carrying your luggage at the bottom of the sea.
- **Key facts:**

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    - When Ambedkar had to return to India from London during World War I in 1917, his luggage and books were sent on a cargo steamer that was torpedoed by a German submarine. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His book collection was dispatched on a different ship from the one he was on, and that ship was torpedoed and sunk by a German submarine."
    -
    - In a letter preserved at Columbia University Library (dated 16 February 1922), Ambedkar told his professor Edwin Seligman that his original doctoral manuscript had gone down with the ship, forcing him to write a brand-new thesis from scratch. | Columbia University Libraries | "Having lost my manuscript of the original thesis when the steamer was torpedoed on my way back to India in 1917 I have written out a new thesis"
    -
    - His LSE professor Herbert Foxwell wrote a glowing letter in November 1920 praising his scholarship when he applied to return to London. | LSE History Blog | "I am sorry we cannot identify him with the School but there are no more worlds here for him to conquer."
    -

Angle 7: The Cup of Water That Shook Mahad

- **One-line hook:** In 1927, the town law in Mahad already said everyone could use the public water tank, yet when Ambedkar knelt to cup a handful of water, it sparked a historic protest.
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- **Key facts:**
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    - Even though the Mahad municipality had legally opened the public Chavdar Tank to all castes, upper-caste residents still barred untouchables from approaching the water. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "He led a satyagraha in Mahad to fight for the right of the untouchable community to draw water from the main water tank of the town."
    -
    - In March 1927, Ambedkar led a procession of thousands to the Chavdar Tank and drank from the water; after upper-caste priests "purified" the tank, he returned to Mahad in December 1927 and burned copies of the ancient law book *Manusmriti*. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "On 25 December 1927, he led thousands of followers to burn copies of Manusmriti."
    -

Angle 8: The Rookie Driver and the River Culvert at Chalisgaon (PERSONAL MEMORY by B. R. Ambedkar)

- **One-line hook:** When every carriage driver at Chalisgaon station refused to drive an untouchable passenger, the villagers put an untrained driver on the reins—and the horse bolted straight toward a river wall.
-
- **Key facts:**
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    - In 1929, Ambedkar got off the train at Chalisgaon to investigate a social boycott of Dalits, and waited an hour at the station because no *tonga* (one-horse carriage) driver would carry an untouchable. | Wikipedia – Waiting for a Visa | "he disembarked at Chalisgaon to investigate a case of social boycott... as the "tonga walas" (one-horse carriage drivers) considered it below their dignity to cart an untouchable"
    -
    - A driver finally agreed to rent his horse and cart only if a Mahar villager drove it, even though the villager barely knew how to steer a horse. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "The tongawala was not prepared to drive the tonga with a Mahar passenger in it, for that would be below his dignity; but he had no objection to hiring out the tonga if a Mahar could be found to drive it."
    -
    - Crossing a bridge over a stream with low side walls, the horse galloped out of control, the wheel struck the side stone, and Ambedkar was thrown onto the stone pavement with a broken leg and severe bruises. | Wikipedia – Waiting for a Visa | "Ambedkar was thrown off the carriage onto the pavement, sustaining multiple injuries, such as a leg fracture."
    -

Angle 9: The Fountain Pen Swap Inside Yerwada Jail

- **One-line hook:** Inside a prison courtyard in 1932, with Mahatma Gandhi weak from a hunger strike, Ambedkar argued for four tense days—and ended the deal by trading fountain pens with C. Rajagopalachari.
-
- **Key facts:**
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    - On 20 September 1932, Mahatma Gandhi began a "fast unto death" inside Yerwada Central Jail in Pune to protest the British government's decision to grant separate voting electorates to the Depressed Classes. | Constitution of India Archive | "On 20th September 1932, while in prison, Gandhi announced a fast unto death till the time separate electorates were removed from the Award."
    -
    - Ambedkar met Gandhi in prison on 22 September, and as Gandhi's health failed, Gandhi's son Devadas burst into the room in tears begging Ambedkar to save his father's life. | Hindustan Times | "Devadas Gandhi burst into the negotiations

and said, “Father is sinking,” pleading before Ambedkar with tears in his eyes."

- At 5:00 PM on 24 September 1932, they signed the Poona Pact giving the Depressed Classes 148 reserved seats in a joint electorate, and C. Rajagopalachari swapped his fountain pen with Ambedkar to mark the signing. | Hindustan Times | "At the end of the talks, Gandhi's trusted emissary, C Rajagopalachari, exchanged his fountain pen with Ambedkar."

Angle 10: Rajgruha — The House Built Around 50,000 Books

- **One-line hook:** Most people buy a house and put a bookshelf inside; B. R. Ambedkar collected so many tens of thousands of books that he had to build a special house in Bombay just to hold them all.
- **Key facts:**
  - In the 1930s, Ambedkar built a residence named *Rajgruha* in the Dadar neighbourhood of Bombay. | Wikipedia – Ambedkar family | "Babasaheb Ambedkar with his family members at Rajgruha, his residence was at Hindu colony of Dadar in Bombay."
  - He filled the house with a personal library of more than 50,000 books, making it one of the largest private book collections in the world. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Settling in Bombay (today called Mumbai), Ambedkar oversaw the construction of a house, and stocked his personal library with more than 50,000 books."

Angle 11: The Boy on the Gunny Sack Who Wrote India's Rulebook

- **One-line hook:** The child who once wasn't allowed to sit on a school bench or touch a classroom water tap grew up to chair the committee that wrote the Constitution for all of independent India—outlawing untouchability forever.
- **Key facts:**
  - In August 1947, upon India's independence, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru invited Ambedkar to serve as the country's first Law Minister, and on 29 August 1947 the Constituent Assembly appointed him Chairman of the Constitution Drafting Committee. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "On 29 August, he was appointed Chairman of the Constitution Drafting Committee, and was appointed by the Assembly to write India's new Constitution."

    - The draft Constitution he guided through the Assembly guaranteed fundamental civil liberties and abolished untouchability across India when it was adopted on 26 November 1949. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "The text prepared by Ambedkar provided constitutional guarantees and protections for a wide range of civil liberties for individual citizens, including freedom of religion, the abolition of untouchability, and the outlawing of all forms of discrimination."
    -

Which angle is the big "flagship" story, and why

- **Flagship story: Angle 1 ("The Midnight Cart Ride to Goregaon") paired with Angle 11 ("The Boy on the Gunny Sack Who Wrote India's Rulebook").**
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- **Why:** For a 10-year-old reader, Ambedkar's own childhood memory of being nine years old on a train platform—dressed neatly, cooking *pulav* with his brothers, and suddenly forced to drive his own bullock cart through the night without a sip of water—makes the unfairness of caste immediately understandable through a child's eyes. Connecting that night to his later work chairing the Drafting Committee that outlawed untouchability in India's Constitution creates a complete, factual arc from boyhood exclusion to writing the laws of a free country.
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3. People and places connected

People and groups

- **Ramji Maloji Sakpal and Bhimabai Sakpal:** Ambedkar's parents; his father was an army Subedar who insisted on educating his children.
-
- **Krishnaji Keshav Ambedkar:** The Marathi Brahmin teacher at Satara High School who changed young Bhimrao's surname from Ambadawekar to Ambedkar in the school records.
-
- **Dada Keluskar:** Author and social reformer who gifted 16-year-old Bhimrao a biography of the Buddha in 1907 and helped introduce him to the Maharaja of Baroda.
-
- **Sayajirao Gaekwad III (Maharaja of Baroda):** Ruler of Baroda State who funded Ambedkar's scholarship to Columbia University in 1913.
-
- **Shahu IV (Maharaja of Kolhapur):** Ruler of Kolhapur who financially supported Ambedkar's first newspaper *Mooknayak* (1920) and his return to London.
-
- **John Dewey and Edwin R. A. Seligman:** Professors at Columbia University in New York who taught and mentored Ambedkar between 1913 and 1916.
-
- **Ramabai Ambedkar:** Ambedkar's first wife, whom he married as a teenager and who died in 1935.
-

- **Mahatma Gandhi (M. K. Gandhi):** Congress leader who fasted in Yerwada Jail in September 1932 against separate electorates, leading to the Poona Pact with Ambedkar.
- **C. Rajagopalachari and Madan Mohan Malaviya:** Hindu leaders who negotiated the 1932 Poona Pact with Ambedkar; Rajagopalachari traded fountain pens with Ambedkar after the signing.
- **Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha, Independent Labour Party, and Scheduled Castes Federation:** Social and political organisations founded by Ambedkar in 1924, 1936, and 1942 to campaign for the education and rights of the Depressed Classes.

Places and events

- **Mhow (Central Provinces / Madhya Pradesh):** British military cantonment town where Ambedkar was born on 14 April 1891.
- **Satara and Masur (Maharashtra):** Where Ambedkar attended high school and where he and his brother were stranded at the railway station on their way to Goregaon in 1901.
- **Columbia University (New York) and London School of Economics / Gray's Inn (London):** The universities and legal inn where Ambedkar earned his M.A., Ph.D., D.Sc., and barrister qualification between 1913 and 1923.
- **10 King Henry's Road, Chalk Farm, London:** The house in London where Ambedkar lived as a student in 1921–1922.
- **Kamathi Baug, Baroda (Vadodara):** The public park where Ambedkar sat weeping for five hours in 1917 after being driven out of a Parsi inn with sticks.
- **Chavdar Tank, Mahad (Maharashtra):** The public water tank where Ambedkar led the Mahad Satyagraha in March and December 1927.
- **Kalaram Temple, Nashik (Maharashtra):** The temple where Ambedkar led 15,000 volunteers in a 1930 temple-entry satyagraha.
- **Yerwada Central Jail, Pune:** The prison where Ambedkar and Gandhi negotiated the Poona Pact in September 1932.
- **Rajgruha, Dadar (Mumbai):** The house Ambedkar built in Bombay in the 1930s to hold his personal library of over 50,000 books.
- **Constituent Assembly Hall, New Delhi:** Where Ambedkar chaired the Drafting Committee of the Indian Constitution from 1947 to 1949.

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4. Disputes, legends and doubts

1. Why did the London School of Economics reject his doctoral thesis *The Problem of the Rupee* in March 1923?

- **Version A (Popular story — rejected for being "too revolutionary and anti-British"):** Many biographies state that British examiners refused to pass his thesis in March 1923 because its critique of British currency policy in India was considered politically dangerous. | LSE History Blog | "Reports claim that the thesis was too revolutionary and anti-British for the examiners."
-
- **Version B (LSE Student Archive — ordinary academic revision with no political objection recorded):** LSE Archivist Sue Donnelly examined Ambedkar's official student file at LSE and found no evidence of political censorship; his examiners asked for revisions in March 1923, he resubmitted in August 1923, and the degree was awarded in November 1923. | LSE History Blog | "However there is no indication of this in Ambedkar's student file... The thesis was resubmitted in August 1923 and accepted in November 1923."
-

2. What was lost when the German submarine torpedoed the steamer in 1917?

- **Version A (Ambedkar's 1922 letter — his original doctoral thesis manuscript was sunk):** In a handwritten letter to Columbia professor Edwin Seligman on 16 February 1922, Ambedkar stated that the manuscript of his original doctoral thesis went down with the torpedoed steamer in 1917. | Columbia University Libraries | "Having lost my manuscript of the original thesis when the steamer was torpedoed on my way back to India in 1917 I have written out a new thesis"
-
- **Version B (Secondary accounts — his luggage and collection of books were sunk):** Secondary accounts such as Wikipedia describe the torpedoed cargo as his personal book collection sent on a separate ship. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "His book collection was dispatched on a different ship from the one he was on, and that ship was torpedoed and sunk by a German submarine."
-

3. Year of his return from London and stay in Baroda (1917 vs. 1918)

- **Version A (Ambedkar's personal memory in *Waiting for a Visa* — 1918):** Writing from memory in 1935–1936, Ambedkar wrote that he went to London in 1917 and returned to Baroda in 1918. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "In 1913 I went to the United States of America, and stayed there till 1917. In 1917 I went to London, and after a short stay of a few months in London I returned to India in 1918."
-
- **Version B (University records and editor's note — 1916 and 1917):** Both LSE student records and Columbia professor Frances Pritchett's editorial note point out that

Ambedkar's memory slipped by one year: he arrived at LSE in October 1916 and returned to Baroda in mid-1917. | Waiting for a Visa (Columbia University) | "[Actually, he spent 1913-1916 in New York, went to London in June 1916, and returned to India in July 1917; these events in Baroda took place chiefly in September 1917.]"

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4. Year of his first marriage to Ramabai (1906 vs. 1907)

- **Version A (1906):** The main biography text on Wikipedia states that he married nine-year-old Ramabai in 1906 when he was 15. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "In 1906, when he was about 15 years old, he married a nine-year-old girl, Ramabai."
-
- **Version B (1907):** The caption on the wedding photograph in the same article dates the marriage to 1907. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Ambedkar with his wife Ramabai in 1907"
-

5. How many seats had the British Communal Award given the Depressed Classes before the 1932 Poona Pact? (70 vs. 71 vs. 80)

- **Version A (70 seats):** The Constitution of India archive states that the Poona Pact's 148 seats was 78 more than the Communal Award had proposed (148 minus 78 = 70 seats). | Constitution of India Archive | "It reserved 148 seats from the general electorate for 'Depressed Classes',78 more than what the Award had proposed."
-
- **Version B (71 seats):** Wikipedia states that the Poona Pact granted 148 seats instead of the 71 allocated by the British Prime Minister Ramsay MacDonald. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "The agreement gave reserved seats for the depressed classes in the Provisional legislatures within the general electorate. Due to the pact, the depressed class received 148 seats in the legislature instead of the 71 as allocated in the Communal Award"
-
- **Version C (80 seats):** *Hindustan Times* reports that the British had allocated 80 seats before the Poona Pact raised the number to 148. | Hindustan Times | "Instead of the 80 seats given by the British, the depressed classes got 148 seats."
-

6. How Ambedkar was chosen for Nehru's first Cabinet in August 1947 (FAMILY MEMORY vs. standard historical accounts)

- **Version A (Standard account — Nehru invited Ambedkar directly):** Standard biographies state that Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru invited Ambedkar to serve as Law Minister in the new Dominion Cabinet in August 1947. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Upon India's independence on 15 August 1947, the new Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru invited Ambedkar to serve as the Dominion of India's Law Minister"
-
- **Version B (FAMILY MEMORY by Indrani Jagjivan Ram):** In her 2010 memoir *Milestones*, Jagjivan Ram's wife Indrani Jagjivan Ram wrote that Ambedkar approached

her husband to ask Vallabhbhai Patel and Mahatma Gandhi to recommend him to Nehru for a Cabinet post. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "Indrani Jagjivan Ram wrote in her memoir Milestones (2010) that Ambedkar had approached her husband, Jagjivan Ram, asking him to persuade Vallabhbhai Patel to include him in independent India's first cabinet."

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7. Exact date of Ambedkar's resignation as Law Minister (1950 vs. 27 September 1951 vs. 6 October 1951)

- **Version A (27 September 1951):** Wikipedia's main text states that Ambedkar resigned from the Cabinet on 27 September 1951 after the Hindu Code Bill was stalled in Parliament. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "On 27 September 1951, Ambedkar resigned from Nehru's cabinet ministry after Hindu code bill was defeated in parliament."
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- **Version B (6 October 1951):** Wikipedia's officeholder infobox lists his term as Minister of Law and Justice ending on 6 October 1951. | Wikipedia – B. R. Ambedkar | "15 August 1947 – 6 October 1951"
-
- **Version C (1950):** The Columbia University Libraries article states that he resigned in 1950. | Columbia University Libraries | "By 1950, feeling frustrated caused by the slow pace of reform, and the defeat of his visionary selective ”Hindu Code Bill”, he resigned from his Ministerial Post"
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5. Pictures

1. File:A photo of Dr. Ambedkar during his years at Columbia, 1913-16.gif | Photograph of B. R. Ambedkar during his student years at Columbia University in New York | Date: between 1913 and 1916 | Licence: Public domain (in India, first published more than 60 years ago)
2.
3. File:Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar in Columbia University.jpg | Portrait of B. R. Ambedkar as a student at Columbia University | Date: Between July 1913 & May 1916 | Licence: Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and Public domain (in India)
4.
5. File:On 29 January 1932, Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar returned to Mumbai after attending Second Round Table Conference in London.jpg | B. R. Ambedkar welcomed by supporters in Mumbai upon returning from the Second Round Table Conference in London | Date: 29 January 1932 | Licence: Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and Public domain (in India)
6.
7. File:M.R. Jayakar, Tej Bahadur Sapru and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar at Yerwada jail, in Poona, on 24 September 1932, the day the Poona Pact was signed.jpg | M. R. Jayakar,

Tej Bahadur Sapru, and B. R. Ambedkar at Yerwada Central Jail in Pune on the day the Poona Pact was signed | Date: 24 September 1932 | Licence: Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and Public domain (in India)

8.
9. File:Dr. Ambedkar in the Parliament.jpg | B. R. Ambedkar in the Constituent Assembly (Parliament) on the day before the Indian Constitution was adopted | Date: 25 November 1949 | Licence: Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and Public domain (in India)
10.
11. File:B.R. Ambedkar in 1950.jpg | Portrait photograph of B. R. Ambedkar | Date: 1950 | Licence: Public domain (in India)
12.
13. File:Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar with Mr. Wallace Stevens at Columbia University after receiving Doctor of Laws (LLD) on June 5, 1952.jpg | B. R. Ambedkar at Columbia University after receiving his honorary Doctor of Laws (LL.D.) degree | Date: 5 June 1952 | Licence: Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and Public domain (in India)
14.
15. File:Dr. Bhimrao Ambedkar.jpg | Studio portrait of B. R. Ambedkar as Minister of Law and Justice | Date: After 1948 or the 1950s | Licence: Public domain (in India and the United States)
16.

6. Sources used

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7. Waiting for a Visa (1935–1936 autobiographical manuscript by Dr. B. R. Ambedkar) — Edited by Prof. Frances W. Pritchett, Columbia University (from *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar: Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 12, Government of Maharashtra)
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9. Poona Pact 1932 (B. R. Ambedkar and M. K. Gandhi) — Constitution of India Archive (Centre for Law and Policy Research)
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11. Gandhi, Ambedkar and the 1932 Poona Pact — Dhrubo Jyoti, *Hindustan Times*
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13. Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar — *Encyclopædia Britannica*
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15. B. R. Ambedkar — Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia
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21. File:A photo of Dr. Ambedkar during his years at Columbia, 1913-16.gif — Wikimedia Commons
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